3.2 Sherman's March and Grant's Victory

Can you think of someone you know who, when challenged by what looks like impossible odds, simply refuses to give up? Historians attribute this kind of persistence to General Grant, especially in the last year of the Civil War.

MAIN IDEA Grant and his generals brought the full power of the Union Army down on the South in their campaign to capture the Confederate capital.

MARCHING THROUGH GEORGIA

In March 1864, President Lincoln named Ulysses S. Grant, the victor of Vicksburg, as commanding general of the Union Army. Grant immediately put a plan in place to wear down the Confederacy with a series of widespread and relentless attacks. Following a Union victory at Chattanooga, Tennessee, in 1864, Grant sent General William T. Sherman to deliver destruction to the heart of the Confederacy—Atlanta, Georgia, which Sherman captured in September 1864. This was an important feat because Atlanta was a railroad hub and the industrial center of the Confederacy.



The city was also a symbol of Confederate pride and strength. Its fall made even the most loyal southerners doubt that they could win the war. "Since Atlanta," South Carolinian Mary Chesnut wrote in her diary, "I have felt as if . . . we are going to be wiped off the earth."

From Atlanta, Sherman marched 62,000 Union troops through Georgia to Savannah, located on the Atlantic shore. His goal was to destroy southern property, crops, and other supplies. Early in 1865, Sherman and his men left Savannah, burning their way northward to Columbia, South Carolina. From there, they marched into North Carolina, battling Confederate troops before destroying the Fayetteville arsenal. In Bentonville, the Confederacy challenged Sherman for three days, but his troops gained the upper hand.

A **total war** is one in which all rules and laws of war are ignored and all resources are poured into defeating the enemy no matter what the cost. Sherman waged total war against the Confederacy, and his strategy was brutal and destructive. But it did what it was meant to do. It was a blow to southern morale and fighting

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AMERICAN PLACES

Savannah Historic District Savannah, Georgia

The Savannah Historic District is a National Historic Landmark. James Oglethorpe founded the city in 1733 when Georgia was a British colony. Savannah's distinctive 18th- and 19th-century architecture is reflected in its numerous historic homes, gardens, and monuments. General Sherman used the Greene-Meldrim House, shown here, as a base of operations between 1864 and 1865. The house was built in 1853 in the Gothic Revival architectural style.

capacity. It led to a feeling in the North that the Union was winning the war and so helped with President Lincoln's reelection in November 1864.

Sherman and his troops spared the city of Savannah instead of burning it as they did Atlanta. Why? There are a number of theories, some more plausible than others. One is that Sherman found Savannah too beautiful to burn. Another is that he was lenient because city leaders surrendered before he could enter the city, agreeing they would not put up a fight if he spared life and property. Perhaps the strongest theory is that Savannah had a large port that could prove very useful to the Union.

GRANT FACES LEE

General Grant was pleased with Sherman's success in the South, and he became even more determined to capture Richmond, Virginia, the Confederate capital. The first large battle of Grant's campaign was the **Battle of the Wilderness**, fought in a heavily wooded area west of Fredericksburg and north of Richmond. The armies engaged in battle for two days with heavy casualties, especially on the Union side. Grant refused to retreat. Instead, he moved his army farther south. Lee followed him. On May 8, 1864, Grant attacked Lee's troops near **Spotsylvania**, beginning a battle that raged for 12 days. The Union's Army of the Potomac lost 18,000 men at the Battle of Spotsylvania; the Confederates lost 12,000. In less than three weeks, Grant had lost 33,000 men. On May 31, Lee and Grant collided again at **Cold Harbor**, where Grant's forces were defeated with heavy losses. The Union lost about 13,000 troops; the Confederates lost only 2,500 or fewer.

In 1865, Grant's forces broke through the last line of Richmond's defenses, and the city fell on April 3. Confederate troops and government officials fled Richmond, setting fire to parts of the city as they left to prevent Union troops from using it for shelter and supplies. The Union took control of what was left of the city. The Confederate capital was captured. President Lincoln traveled to Richmond a few days later to see the evidence of this significant Union victory for himself.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** What was Grant's strategy in the South?
2. **ANALYZE LANGUAGE USE** Mary Chesnut used a figurative expression to describe how she felt about the fall of Atlanta. How did she articulate how she felt about the war? Use evidence from the text to support your answer.
3. **MAKE PREDICTIONS** What effect could you predict the Union capture of Richmond would have on the Civil War's outcome?

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